

*A Wizard of Earthsea*, Chapters 5-7

1. Chapter 5 opens with a long geographical digression on the Ninety Isles: the uncountable islands, the tides that merge three isles into one, the nets strung between houses. Why does Le Guin pause the plot for cartography? What work does this passage do that a single sentence of scene-setting could not?
2. The wealth of the Ninety Isles is turbie-oil; the wealth of Osskil is gold; Pendor's wealth is a pirate hoard under a dragon. Track how each economy in these chapters shapes the social relations built on top of it. What is Le Guin doing with money in a fantasy novel that mostly avoids it?
3. The narrator tells us that the Old Speech binds humans to truth, but dragons can lie in it, "twisting the true words to false ends." Work out the implications: what does it mean for a language to be identical with reality for one species and merely native for another? Who actually owns this language?
4. During the sail to Pendor, Ged reflects that for the first time since Roke Knoll he feels free, precisely because he chose this danger himself. What theory of freedom is being proposed here, where liberty appears only inside voluntarily accepted risk? Test it against Ged's later flight, which is compelled.
5. Ged's payment from Low Torning is ten ivory counters, which the Osskilian shipmaster refuses because "we do not use those counters." A wizard's staff, we are told elsewhere, is "passport and payment on most ships," but not on this one. What do incompatible currencies signal about Osskil before Ged ever sets foot there?
6. Compare the two crews Ged rows with: the trading partners of the Andradean ships, where crewmen share profit, and the Osskilian galley, where bondsmen row under the whip beside paid freemen. The narrator remarks that gold "is not a source of good fellowship." Build the political argument implicit in this contrast.
7. In the dead land, Ged recognizes constellations that never appear in the living sky, and he knows their names: the Sheaf, the Door, the One Who Turns, the Tree. He has never been there, yet the knowledge is already in him. What does this detail imply about the relationship between wizardly learning and death in Earthsea?
8. The narrator explains that a gebbeth is a husk, "an unreal flesh clothing the shadow which is real." The possessed body is less real than the possessing shadow. What ontology is at work here, where absence has more substance than presence? Connect this to the book's account of what illusion is.
9. The shadow cannot be seen in daylight and takes shape only "in dream and darkness," yet its power over Ged operates continuously through his fear, his sleeplessness, and his mistrust of strangers. Distinguish between what the shadow can actually do and what Ged's anticipation of it does. Where is the real damage happening in Chapter 6?
10. The otak refuses to eat at Serd and hides in Ged's pocket for the entire journey north. The animal registers the shadow's approach before Ged consciously does. Having read Chapter 5's lesson about the wisdom of beasts, what is the significance of Ged noticing the otak's fear but not acting on it?